



Air support

During the Vietnam War, the assault on Hill 875 in November 1967 saw the US 173rd Airborne Brigade walk into an ambush by the North Vietnamese. This was followed by one of the worst friendly fire incidents of the war, when a bomb dropped by a US fighter-bomber detonated over American forces. The only efficient means of evacuation for the wounded, as in other operations of the war, was to be airlifted out.

It was here, in Vietnam, that the helicopter truly came into its own. The Bell UH-1 Iroquois, known as the “Huey” after its HU designation, was the first turbine-powered helicopter in the US military. In the difficult terrain of South Vietnam, the Huey was used in Medevac (medical evacuation) operations, airlifting wounded troops to field hospitals. To overcome the problems of relocating the wounded to landing sites, a winch system was used to hoist patients up to the hovering helicopter. The role of an air ambulance crew member was a high-risk one, with around a third of those serving becoming casualties themselves.

AN ALL-ROUNDER

Although initially conceived for a Medevac role, the Huey was also used to transport troops and cargo, and for air assault, search and rescue, and ground attack. It remains in operation, and is still in use in the US military as well as in the military forces of numerous countries worldwide.

A Huey air ambulance hovers as victims of the 1967 assault on Hill 875 are helped aboard by fellow members of the 173rd Airborne Brigade.